



Kilts and Celtic Style

A Guide for the Women of the Krewe of Shamrock

Irish and Scottish heritage, feminine style, and what to wear on parade day and at the ball

Can women wear kilts?

Yes. Women can wear kilts, and in the Krewe of Shamrock they do so proudly. The kilt is a versatile garment that belongs to anyone who wants to honor Celtic heritage. The traditional kilt is most closely associated with Scottish men, but women in Scotland, Ireland, and across the Irish and Scottish diaspora have been wearing kilts and kilted skirts for well over a century.

In Scotland, kilts made for women are often called “kilted skirts.” They are cut to sit closer to the body than a man’s kilt, and they are usually available in several lengths. Some women prefer the fuller, heavier men’s style, so tell your kilt maker which you want when you order. You can even ask for the closure to be reversed so the apron wraps left over right, the way other women’s garments close. A woman’s kilt can be made from the same wool as a man’s and can be accessorized in the same way, with a sporran, kilt hose, and kilt pin, or it can be styled in a softer, more feminine direction. This guide covers both.

In recent years the women’s kilt has also become a fashion piece in its own right. Designers offer kilts in mini, midi, and ankle lengths, in wool tartan, solid saffron, tweed, and even leather. A kilt can be worn casually with boots and a sweater, dressed up with a corset and a Celtic brooch for parade day, or made formal for a ball. Whatever your style, there is a way to wear a kilt that feels like you.

A little Celtic heritage

The Krewe of Shamrock was founded in 1999 by five friends who wanted a krewe of their own, and from the first parade its members marched in kilts with bagpipes playing. The krewe draws on both Irish and Scottish traditions, so it helps to know a little about each.

The Scottish tradition

The kilt as we know it descends from the Highland great kilt, or belted plaid, a long length of wool that was pleated and belted at the waist with the remainder thrown over the shoulder. In the eighteenth century the lower half was tailored into the “small kilt,” which is the pleated, wrap-around garment worn today. Scottish tartans are tied to clans, families, districts, and regiments, and many women choose a tartan from their own family line.

The Irish tradition

The Irish kilt is younger than many people assume. It came into use during the Gaelic Revival of the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, when Irish nationalists were looking for a distinctly national form of dress. Rather than tartan, they chose solid saffron, a warm golden-orange color, and sometimes solid green. Patrick Pearse adopted the saffron kilt for his school, St. Enda’s, founded in 1908, and Irish pipe bands took it up soon after. To this day the saffron kilt is the most traditional Irish choice and is still worn by Irish military pipers.

Irish tartans are a more recent development. The Ulster tartan is based on cloth found near Londonderry that dates to the early 1600s and was reproduced in 1958. The Irish National tartan and the popular Irish County tartans (Cork, Kerry, Galway, Dublin, and so on) were designed in the second half of the twentieth century by Scottish weavers and hold no official standing with the Irish government. That does not make them any less meaningful to wear. They are a modern and heartfelt way to show the county your family came from, and they look wonderful on parade day.

What this means for you: there is no wrong choice. A woman with Irish roots might choose a saffron kilt, a county tartan, or the Irish National tartan. A woman with Scottish roots might wear her clan tartan. A woman with both, or with neither but with a love of the culture, can wear whichever she finds most beautiful. Green, gold, and white are the colors most associated with Ireland and with the Krewe, so any tartan that carries those colors will look right at home in our parade line.

Kilt, kilted skirt, or tartan skirt: what is the difference?

These three terms get used loosely, and it is worth knowing what each one means before you shop.

- **Kilt.** A true kilt is made from a single length of fabric, traditionally about eight yards of wool, that is knife-pleated across the back and wraps around the body with a flat front apron. The pleats are sewn down at the hip and swing free below. A kilt closes with leather straps and buckles and is worn with a kilt pin on the front apron. Men’s kilts wrap left over right; women’s are often made either way.
- **Kilted skirt.** A kilted skirt is built the same way as a kilt but uses less fabric, sits closer to the body, and is available in mini, knee, midi, and ankle lengths. It is lighter and cooler than a full kilt, which matters in Florida, and it is the style most women’s kilt makers offer by default. Many women in the Krewe wear kilted skirts and simply call them kilts, which is perfectly fine.
- **Tartan skirt.** A tartan skirt is any skirt sewn from tartan cloth, whether A-line, pencil, pleated all the way around, or circle cut. It is made from several pieces of fabric sewn together rather than one wrapped length. It reads as Celtic and is welcome in the parade, but it is not a kilt in the strict sense.

The Krewe’s parade rule asks for Celtic themed attire, so any of the three will do. If you want the swing of the pleats when you walk and the authentic look in photographs, choose a kilt or a kilted skirt.

Choosing your kilt

Tartan or solid

- **Irish county or family tartan.** The most personal choice for a woman honoring Irish roots. Look up the county your family emigrated from.
- **Irish National tartan.** A green, gold, and white design that works for anyone with Irish heritage or Irish pride.
- **Saffron.** The traditional solid Irish kilt color. It photographs beautifully next to green and is very easy to accessorize.
- **Scottish clan or district tartan.** If your family name is Scottish, this is the classic option.
- **Universal tartans.** Black Watch, Hunting Stewart, and similar designs are considered open to everyone and pair well with green Krewe shirts.

Length

Length is a matter of comfort and taste. Knee length is the most traditional and the most flattering on most figures. Mini kilts are popular and fun but remember that you will be walking four miles and climbing on and off floats, so make sure you can move comfortably. Midi and ankle lengths, sometimes called hostess length, look elegant and are a good choice for evening events.

Fit and ordering

- Measure your natural waist, your hips at the widest point, and the length from your natural waist to where you want the hem to fall. Kilts sit at the natural waist, higher than most modern skirts.
- Tell the kilt maker whether you want a ladies' kilted skirt or a men's-style kilt, and which side you want the apron to close on.
- Ask about weight. Thirteen ounce wool is standard; lighter weights and poly-viscose blends are cooler for Florida and easier to care for.
- **Order early.** Custom kilts from Scotland or Ireland can take six to twelve weeks. Ready-to-wear kilted skirts in stock tartans ship much faster.

Feminine style with your kilt

A kilt is a wonderful canvas. Below are the pieces Krewe women reach for most, from the parade route to the ballroom.

Tops

- **Corset or bodice.** A tartan, leather, or brocade corset over a white blouse is the signature parade look for many Krewe women. Choose a style you can breathe and walk in, and wear a camisole or blouse underneath for comfort and coverage.
- **Celtic blouse.** A white or cream peasant blouse, a chemise with lace or bell sleeves, or a fitted Jacobite-style shirt all read as Celtic and pair with any tartan.

- **Krewe t-shirt.** Always acceptable and always welcome. Tie it at the waist or tuck it in to keep the line of the kilt.
- **Sweaters and vests.** A fitted Aran cable sweater, a cropped cardigan, or a tartan or tweed waistcoat looks polished and adds warmth.

Accessories (always optional)

- **Kilt pin.** Worn on the lower corner of the front apron to weigh it down. Look for shamrock, Celtic knot, Claddagh, or thistle designs.
- **Brooch.** A Tara brooch or a penannular brooch at the shoulder holds a sash or shawl and is one of the most recognizably Irish pieces you can wear.
- **Tartan sash or shawl.** A sash in your tartan worn over the right shoulder and pinned at the left hip, or draped over the left shoulder, is the traditional women's alternative to a man's fly plaid. A wool shawl doubles as warmth on a cold parade morning.
- **Sporran or bag.** A sporran is traditional and practical. A small crossbody bag in leather or tartan is a comfortable alternative for the walk.
- **Jewelry.** Claddagh rings, Celtic knot earrings, Trinity knot pendants, and shamrock charms all suit the day. Green and gold beads are festive for the parade.
- **Hose and flashes.** Knee-high kilt hose in cream, green, or black with ribbon flashes finish the look. Tights or knee socks work just as well and are warmer.
- **Shoes.** Ghillie brogues are traditional. For the four mile parade route most members choose comfortable boots or athletic shoes, and that is encouraged. Save the heels for the ball.

Hair, makeup, and headwear

You bring your style. Traditional braids, a crown braid, or loose waves with a tartan ribbon or a small flower crown feel Celtic and stay put in the wind. A tam or a Glengarry bonnet is a fun option. For makeup, a touch of green or gold on the eyes and a shamrock or Celtic face design is popular for parade day; keep it in good taste, because the Krewe marches in front of families.

Layering for weather

Parade days in Tampa can be surprisingly cold, especially in January at Gasparilla. Plan for layers: a wool shawl, a fitted jacket, a tartan scarf, or a long coat over your kilt. Fingerless gloves keep hands warm while you throw beads. A pair of leggings under a kilted skirt is invisible under hose and makes a big difference on a windy morning.

Famous female kilt-wearers

Here are some famous women who have worn kilts:

- **Princess Diana:** The late Princess Diana, former wife of Prince Charles, was often seen wearing kilts, both in Scotland and on her travels around the world. Diana's embrace of the kilt helped to popularize this traditional garment among women.
- **Angelina Jolie:** American actress Angelina Jolie is known for her fashion-forward style and has been seen wearing a kilt on several occasions, including the premiere of her film "Maleficent."

- **Madonna:** American singer and actress Madonna has been known to incorporate kilts into her eclectic fashion sense. In the 1990s, Madonna was often seen wearing kilts, both on stage and in her personal life.
- **Emma Watson:** British actress Emma Watson has been seen wearing a kilt on several occasions, including the premiere of her film “Beauty and the Beast.” Watson’s embrace of the kilt has helped to demonstrate that this traditional garment can be worn in a modern and stylish way.
- **Sarah Jessica Parker:** American actress Sarah Jessica Parker, best known for her role as Carrie Bradshaw in the television series “Sex and the City,” has been seen wearing a kilt on several occasions.
- **Gwyneth Paltrow:** American actress Gwyneth Paltrow has been seen wearing a kilt on several occasions, including at the premiere of her film “Shakespeare in Love.”
- **Kirsten Dunst:** American actress Kirsten Dunst has been seen wearing a kilt on several occasions, including the premiere of her film “Spider-Man.”
- **Uma Thurman:** American actress Uma Thurman has been seen wearing a kilt on several occasions, including the premiere of her film “Kill Bill.”
- **Lady Gaga:** American singer Lady Gaga is known for her bold fashion choices and has been seen wearing a kilt on several occasions, including in her music videos and during her concerts.

Krewe of Shamrock parade attire rules

These rules apply to every parade participant, members and guests alike. Members are responsible for making sure their guests are in appropriate attire. The rules do not apply to security personnel.

- **Celtic attire is required.** All participants must be in Celtic themed attire. In practice this means everyone is kilted or in another clearly Celtic outfit. No street clothes are allowed.
- **Tops.** Some women wear a corset with their kilt. Any Celtic style blouse or a Krewe t-shirt is also fine.
- **Shoes.** Wear comfortable shoes for walking. The parade route is about four miles, and many members wear athletic shoes.
- **Weather.** Gasparilla is often a cold day. Men and women alike wear coats, and that is expected.
- **Decency.** Indecent dress will not be tolerated, including inappropriate or explicit t-shirts.
- **No weapons.** Firearms, sharp objects, and weapons of any kind are strictly prohibited, even if they would be considered part of a costume. This includes decorative sgian dubhs (the small knife traditionally worn in the kilt hose) and prop swords.
- **Wristbands.** When applicable, all participants must wear the wristbands provided and keep them visible while on the parade route. Participants without wristbands will not be allowed onto the route or into the parade.
- **Name badges.** Krewe of Shamrock members are encouraged to wear their name badges.

Formal events: the Tartan Ball, balls, and parties

At formal Krewe events such as the Tartan Ball, women wear formal dresses, ball gowns, and evening gowns. Tartan is welcome but not required. If you would like to bring Celtic heritage into your formal look, here are some graceful ways to do it.

- **Optional tartan sash over a gown.** The classic Scottish evening look for women is a plain gown, often in a solid color, with a tartan sash pinned at the shoulder with a brooch. It is elegant, easy, and lets you wear your family tartan without a full tartan gown.
- **Evening gown.** A formal gown, usually full length but not required. Bring your style.
- **Tartan or saffron gown.** Some designers make full evening gowns in tartan or in saffron silk. These make a statement and photograph wonderfully.
- **Celtic details.** A Tara brooch, Claddagh jewelry, a Celtic knot hair comb, a green or gold wrap, or shamrock embroidery on a clutch are all subtle nods to heritage.
- **Comfort.** Balls involve dancing. Choose shoes you can dance in and a gown you can move in.

Parade day checklist

- ✿ Kilt or kilted skirt, with kilt pin on the front apron
- ✿ Corset, Celtic blouse, or Krewe t-shirt
- ✿ Hose or tights, plus flashes if you like them
- ✿ Comfortable walking shoes
- ✿ Shawl, jacket, or coat for cold weather
- ✿ Sporran or small crossbody bag
- ✿ Wristband on and visible, name badge on
- ✿ Nothing sharp and nothing that could be mistaken for a weapon
- ✿ Beads to throw, water to drink, and a smile for the crowd

✿ *All for Fun and Fun for All.* ✿